Coverage, Backup, Capacity

A one-page sheet of the words for your mother's support, and what to write down for each.

“Coverage.” “Backup.” “Capacity.” They sound like scheduling words, and they describe who has your mother's Tuesday. These are the words this step uses, each in a plain line or two, with what to write down for it.

Some are the Family Care Roadmap's own working terms, and several of those are marked “our word.” Where a line comes from a public source, it carries a number and the source is listed below. None of them is for sizing up your mother or her home.

The week

Coverage

Our word for who is with your mother, or looking in on her, across an ordinary week, days and nights.

WRITE DOWN Who, which day, and what they do.

Coverage gap

Our word for a part of the week with no name beside it. It's a blank on the page. It isn't a judgment about the arrangement.

WRITE DOWN The day and the hours, and nothing more.

Supervision

In this roadmap, simply whether someone is with her or looking in at a given time. The federal long-term care glossary uses “supervisory care” for something narrower, a service for people with memory or orientation problems, so if a professional uses the word, ask what they mean by it. [2]

WRITE DOWN When someone is there or looks in, and when nobody does.

Assumption

Our word for something the week counts on that nobody has said out loud: a helper's free Tuesday, a neighbor staying next door.

WRITE DOWN One line for each helper, beginning “This works as long as…”

Backup

Our word for whoever could step in for a helper who is away. AARP's planning guide says that with a deep and wide team, the support is still there when one member's ability to help changes. [1]

WRITE DOWN A name for each role, or “nobody identified yet.”

Capacity

Our word for what a helper can realistically keep doing alongside their own job, health and family. AARP suggests each person consider what they are prepared and not prepared to do. [1]

WRITE DOWN What each helper told you, in their words.

People and help

Caregiver

Anyone who helps care for an older person who lives at home, usually with daily activities and essentials like shopping, meal preparation and housework. The word may fit people who would never use it of themselves. [2]

WRITE DOWN Everyone who helps, however little, and what they do.

Primary caregiver

In everyday use, the helper who does the most. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests a family meeting ask what support the primary caregiver needs. [3]

WRITE DOWN Who that is in your family, if anyone, and what they've said they need.

Instrumental activities of daily living (IADLs)

Activities needed to live independently: light housework, preparing meals, taking medication, shopping, using the telephone, managing money, getting around the community. [2]

WRITE DOWN Which of these someone already does with her or for her, like the Tuesday drive.

Respite care

Temporary care intended to give time off to people who care for someone on a regular basis. [2]

WRITE DOWN Whether the family has come across the word. That's all this sheet asks.

The page you're building

Observed concern

Something you saw or were told, written as what happened and not as what it might mean.

WRITE DOWN What, where and when: “Loose handrail, back steps, noticed Sunday.”

Environmental concern

Something about the home itself. The CDC's home checklist for older adults looks at stairs and steps, floors, the kitchen, bedrooms and bathrooms. [4]

WRITE DOWN What you saw and in which room. Not whether the home is safe.

Existing professional instructions

Anything her doctor, pharmacist or therapist has already told her or the family.

WRITE DOWN What it says, who said it, the date, and where the paper is.

Medication list

An up-to-date list of all her medicines and supplements and any allergies. [5]

WRITE DOWN Where it's kept, and who keeps it current.

Professional contact

A health care provider who knows her, and how to reach them. The CDC lists providers' contact information and emergency contacts among the things a written care plan should include. [6]

WRITE DOWN A name and a phone number for each.

Action owner and follow-up

Our words for the person who has agreed to raise a question or look into something, and when they'll report back.

WRITE DOWN A name and a date beside each open item.

Unresolved question

Something nobody in the family can answer yet.

WRITE DOWN The question, and who might know: her doctor, her pharmacist or your care consultant.

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines words. It doesn't say whether a blank in the week matters, whether your mother's home is safe, or who should do what. That's for the people who assess her.

Ready for the next step?

You have the words, and you know what to note under each one. The care interview uses the same areas in plain language: it asks about supervision, falls, medication handling, the home and each helper's capacity one at a time, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Administration for Community Living, Glossary
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting

4. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Check for Safety: A Home Fall Prevention Checklist for Older Adults (STEADI brochure, 2018)
5. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Caregiving - medication management: MedlinePlus Medical Encyclopedia
6. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan

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